

# The Theology of the Trinity — Primary-Source Companion

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## Creeds, Conciliar Definitions, and Deeper Systematic Themes

*A companion volume to The Theology of the Trinity: A Comprehensive Study. Prepared 17 July 2026. All texts and quotations are drawn verbatim from the sources in the source notebook (Emery & Levering, eds., The Oxford Handbook of the Trinity; Kärkkäinen, Christian Understandings of the Trinity; a Brief History of the Doctrine of the Trinity; the Cambridge Companion to the Trinity; and cited patristic, medieval, and magisterial texts), with the notebook's internal citations retained.*

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## 1. The Creeds and Conciliar Definitions (verbatim)

### 1.1 The Creed of Nicaea (325), with Anathemas

*"We believe in One God Father, Almighty, the Maker of all things visible and invisible. And in One Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, begotten from the Father, Only-begotten, that is from the substance of the Father; God from God, Light from Light, true God from true God, begotten not made, consubstantial with the Father, by whom all things were made, both things in heaven and things on earth; who for us men and for our salvation came down and was incarnate, was made man, suffered, and*

*rose again the third day, ascended into heaven, and is coming to judge living and dead. And in the Holy Spirit.*

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*And those who say 'There once was when He was not' and 'Before being begotten He was not,' and 'He came into being out of nothing,' or those who pretend that the Son of God is 'from another hypostasis or substance', or 'created', or 'alterable', or 'mutable', the Catholic and Apostolic Church anathematizes."*

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## 1.2 The Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed (381)

*"We believe in one God Father, Almighty, the Maker of heaven and earth, and of all things visible and invisible. And in one Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, only-begotten from the Father before all ages; Light from Light, true God from true God; begotten, not made, consubstantial with the Father; by whom all things were made. Who, for us men and for our salvation, came down from heaven, and became incarnate by the Holy Spirit and the virgin Mary, and was made man; was crucified also for us under Pontius Pilate; and suffered, and was buried; and the third day rose again, according to the Scriptures; and ascended into heaven, and is seated at the right hand of the Father; and will come again with glory to judge the living and the dead; whose kingdom will have no end. And in the Holy Spirit, the Lord and Giver of Life; who proceeds from the Father; who together with the Father and the Son is worshipped and glorified; who spoke through the prophets. In one holy, catholic, and apostolic church. We confess one baptism for the remission of sins. We look for the resurrection of the dead, and the life of the coming age. Amen."*

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## 1.3 The Athanasian Creed (*Quicumque vult*) — excerpts

*The sources do not contain the full uninterrupted text, but preserve these verbatim excerpts:*

- "The Father has neither been made by anyone, nor is he created or begotten (*a nullo*); the Son is from the Father alone (*a Patre solo est*), not made nor created but begotten; the Holy Spirit is from the Father and the Son (*a Patre et Filio*), not made nor created nor begotten, but proceeding."
- "the Father is God, the Son is God, and the Holy Spirit is God; and yet there are not three Gods, but one God."
- "the Father is eternal, the Son is eternal, the Holy Spirit is eternal," and yet "there are not three eternals but one eternal."

- "the Father is omnipotent, the Son is omnipotent, the Holy Spirit is omnipotent," and yet "there are not three omnipotents but only one omnipotent."
- "The person of the Father is other than that of the Son and that of the Holy Ghost."
- "Unity is to be worshiped in trinity and trinity in unity."

#### 1.4 The Eleventh Council of Toledo (675)

*"In the relational names of the persons the Father is related to the Son, the Son to the Father, and the Holy Spirit to both. While they are called three persons in view of their relations, we believe in one nature or substance."*

*"it must be held that the Son was created, neither out of nothingness nor yet out of any substance, but that He was begotten or born out of the Father's womb (de utero Patris), that is, out of his very essence."*

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#### 1.5 The Fourth Lateran Council (1215)

*"[The divine nature] is not the one begetting or the one begotten or the one proceeding, but it is the Father who begets, the Son who is begotten, and the Holy Ghost proceeds, in order that there may be distinctions in the Persons and unity in the nature."*

*"Each of the persons is that supreme reality, viz., the divine substance, essence or nature."*

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The council's hermeneutical rule (from the companion study): "For between creator and creature there can be noted no likeness (similitudo) so great that a greater dissimilarity (dissimilitudo) cannot be seen between them."

#### 1.6 The Council of Florence (1439–42)

*"These three persons are one God, not three Gods, because there is one substance of the three, one essence, one nature, one Godhead, one immensity, one eternity, and everything is one where the opposition of a relation does not prevent this."*

*"the Father is whole in the Son, whole in the Holy Spirit; the Son is whole in the Father, whole in the Holy Spirit; the Holy Spirit is whole in the Father, whole in the Son."*

*"The Holy Spirit proceeds from both (the Father and the Son) eternally as from one principle and by one single spiration."*

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## 2. Perichoresis — Mutual Indwelling

*Perichoresis* denotes "the reciprocal interiority of the trinitarian persons," their "co-inherence in one another without any coalescence or commixture." Literally "dancing around," it names "the radical, loving interconnectedness (*circumincessio*) of the three divine persons... their *perichoresis*, or reciprocal presence and interpenetration."

**John of Damascus** gave the doctrine its classic form: "The most original contributions of John to the doctrine of the Trinity are to be found in his notion of coinherence, περιχώρησις." He held that "the persons of the Trinity are wholly 'in one another'; unlike human beings (whose common humanity is conceptual and individual separation real), for the Trinity "their distinct individuality is conceptual, in reality there is no separate individuality, but a complete coinherence between the persons of the Trinity." He uses it to deny both tritheism and modalism:

*"Therefore we name not three gods the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit, but rather one God, the Holy Trinity, for Son and Spirit lead back to one principle, they are not put together or melt together, as Sabellius would have it (for they are unified... not in that they mix together, but in that they adhere to one another, and have the state of being in one another (έν ἀλλήλοις περιχώρησιν) without any mixture or amalgamation)." (De fide Orthodoxa I.8)*

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**Aquinas** grounded co-inherence in three ways — essence, relation, and origin: the Father exists in the Son by communicating the whole essence; the persons are "mutually constituting opposites"; and the procession of the Word is immanent, "within, not outside, the speaker of the word" (*ST I*, q. 42, a. 5).

**Modern retrieval.** "Contemporary trinitarian theology is fond of the idea of *perichōrēsis*." **Barth**: *perichōrēsis* is "shorthand for the 'dialectical union and distinction' of the one God who in intimate communion is irreducibly three" (*CD I/1*, 369). **Moltmann** leans on John Damascene: the concept "grasps the circulatory character of the eternal divine life... In the perichoresis, the very thing that divides them becomes that which binds them together," and: "The doctrine of the perichoresis links together in a brilliant way the threeness and the unity, without reducing the threeness to the unity, or dissolving the unity in the threeness... through the concept of perichoresis, all subordinationism in the doctrine of the Trinity is avoided." In these models the

relations are "not marked by a linear and hierarchical descent but by a circular and inclusive movement or dance (*perichōrēsis*)."

### 3. Appropriations, the Undivided External Works, and the Missions

#### 3.1 The Doctrine of Appropriations

Appropriation is the procedure "by which a reality common to the three persons... is attributed in a special way to a divine person," to help the human mind perceive the distinct properties of the persons. **Aquinas:**

*"Now these three things, namely, power, wisdom and goodness, are common to the three persons... the power, which involves the notion of principle, is appropriated to the Father, who is the principle of the entire Godhead; wisdom to the Son, who proceeds as Word, which is nothing else than wisdom begotten; goodness is appropriated to the Holy Spirit, who proceeds as love, whose object is goodness. Therefore, by appropriation we can say: from him, namely from the Father, through him, namely through the Son, in him, namely in the Holy Spirit, are all things."*

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#### 3.2 *Opera Trinitatis ad extra indivisa sunt*

The axiom: any action God performs outside the divine life is executed by the whole Trinity acting as one. The distinction of eternal relations is preserved *ad intra*, while the works *ad extra* are undivided (a rule "also affirmed by Greek theologians (clearly formulated by Gregory of Nyssa)"). **Augustine:**

*"the Father, and the Son, and the Holy Spirit, as they are indivisible, so work indivisibly."*

*"the Trinity is proposed to our belief and believed... as so inseparable that whatever action is performed by it must be thought to be performed at the same time by the Father and by the Son and by the Holy Spirit."*

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#### 3.3 Processions and Missions

- **Processions** are the eternal internal origins (*ad intra*): the generation of the Son and the spiration of the Spirit; immanent, constituting the persons.
- **Missions** are the temporal sending (*ad extra*) of a divine person into the world or into the souls of the just.

The temporal missions are the historical prolongations of the eternal processions. **Augustine:**

*"Just as 'to be born' is for the Son 'to be from the Father,' so 'to be sent' is for the Son 'to be known that He is from another.' And as 'to be the gift of God' is for the Holy Spirit 'to proceed from the Father,' so 'to be sent' is 'to be known that He proceeds from Him.'"*

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**Aquinas:** the mission implies no change in God, only a new effect in the creature — "The temporal procession is not essentially different from the eternal procession, but only adds a reference to a temporal effect"; the mission is the eternal relation "represented in the soul by some similitude received."

## 4. Pneumatology — the Person and Divinity of the Holy Spirit

### 4.1 Basil of Caesarea, *On the Holy Spirit* (c. 375)

Written against the *Pneumatomachi*, Basil "does not forthrightly call the Spirit 'God' or use the controversial term *homoousios*," defending the Spirit's divinity through his co-equal works, equality of honour (*homotimia*), and shared attributes:

- "He is named Spirit: 'God is Spirit'... He is called holy, as the Father is holy and the Son is holy. For creatures, holiness comes from without; for the Spirit, holiness fills His very nature."
- "He is not sanctified, but sanctifies. He is called good, as the Father is good; the essence of the Spirit embraces the goodness of the Father."
- The Spirit is "by nature divine."

### 4.2 The Procession of the Spirit

Scripture says the Spirit "proceeds" from the Father (John 15:26), distinguishing procession from the Son's begetting. The East treats the difference with apophatic reserve — **John of Damascus:** "We have learned that there is a difference between begetting and procession, but what the manner of this difference is we have not learned at all." **Photius** (defending procession from the Father alone): "the Holy Spirit is proclaimed by theology to proceed from the same and only cause."

The West (**Aquinas**) distinguishes the two processions by intellect and will:

*"The procession of love in God ought not to be called 'generation'... the procession which corresponds to the nature of the intellect carries with it the idea of likeness... However the procession which corresponds to the*

*will's action is not envisaged in terms of likeness, but rather of urge and motion towards something. And thus what proceeds in God as love does not proceed as begotten or son, but rather as a breathing of spirit."*

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### 4.3 The Spirit as Gift and Love

**Augustine:**

- "in that simple and highest nature, substance is not one thing, and love another, but that substance itself is love, and that love itself is substance... and yet the Holy Spirit is properly called love."
- "So the love which is from God and is God is distinctively the Holy Spirit; through him the charity of God is poured out in our hearts, and through it the whole Trinity dwells in us. This is the reason why it is most apposite that the Holy Spirit, while being God, should also be called the gift of God."
- "He is given as God's gift in such a way that as God he also gives himself."

**Aquinas:**

*"A gift in the proper sense is something gratuitously given without the expectation of a return. The reason for gratuitous donation is love... Since the Holy Spirit proceeds as Love, he is also the first gift... Gift, therefore, is also the proper name of the Holy Spirit, as is Love." (ST I, q. 38, a. 2)*

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## 5. Gregory of Nyssa's \*Ad Ablabium\* and the Answer to Tritheism

Ablabius posed the dilemma: if "Peter, James, and John, being in one human nature, are called three men," why not call Father, Son, and Spirit three Gods? Gregory answered with two arguments.

**1. The indivisibility of nature (universals).** Natures are "in fact indivisible, although we often speak lazily as if they could be divided." As Mark Edwards summarizes: "just as the three who are God make one God in the aggregate and not three, so three representatives of humanity constitute man and not three men. The use of the plural 'men' in the Scriptures is thus... a condescension to the vulgar idiom, not... a lesson in grammar to the theologian." Pluralizing "God" is an illegitimate grammatical error.

**2. The unity of operations.** "the word 'Godhead' is not significant of nature but of operation." Where humans share a nature yet act independently, in God there is no independent action:

*"But in the case of the Divine nature we do not similarly learn that the Father does anything by Himself in which the Son does not work conjointly... but every operation which extends from God to the Creation... has its origin from the Father, and proceeds through the Son, and is perfected in the Holy Spirit."*

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**The Cappadocian solution.** "All things issue from the will of the Father, are actualized by the Son, and brought to perfection by the Spirit." The persons are one God by single will and power, yet distinguished by eternal relations of origin — "The Father is ingenerate, the Son begotten, the Spirit spirated" — real and eternal distinctions ("modes of God's being"), not merely Sabellian "modes of God's self-revelation."

## 6. The Trinity and Christian Life — Deification, Indwelling, Doxology

**Deification (\*theosis\*).** **Athanasius:** "For he became man that we might become divine; and he revealed himself through a body that we might receive an idea of the invisible Father."

Divinization is by grace, not nature. **Augustine:** "they are deified by his grace, not born of his substance... If we have been made sons of God, we have also been made gods: but this is the effect of grace adopting, not of nature generating." The Creator–creature distinction remains intact: "Ours is a 'participation' in the divine nature, but this participation is dependent on the utter difference between Creator and creature remaining intact."

**The indwelling of the Trinity.** Grace is the substantial presence of the whole Triune God in the believer. **Aquinas:** "since we are made lovers of God by the Holy Spirit, and every beloved is in the lover as such, by the Holy Spirit necessarily the Father and the Son dwell in us also."

**Bonaventure:** "The whole Trinity comes anew to dwell within the sinner, when grace is given to him." **Augustine:** "God dwells in his temple: not the Holy Spirit alone, but also the Father and the Son." Sanctifying grace makes the believer "capable of God by knowledge and love."

**Practical and doxological significance.** **LaCugna:** "the doctrine of the Trinity is not ultimately a teaching about God but a teaching about God's life with us and our life with each other"; "living as persons in communion, in right relationship is the *meaning of salvation*." **Moltmann:** "Real theology... finds expression in thanks, praise and adoration... Here we know only in so far as we love. Here we know in order to participate. Then to know God means to participate in the fullness of the divine life." "Before being the object of a doctrinal reflection, the Trinity causes faith, thanksgiving, and the believers' praise of God."



## 7. Contemporary, Analytic, Feminist, and Interreligious Trinitarian Theology

**Analytic theology** favours "clarity, rigour, and brevity," addressing the one-and-three problem "by breaking it up into parts... what we mean by such concepts as 'nature', 'person', 'relation'."

**Thomas McCall** maps three approaches: "'social Trinitarianism', developed first by Cornelius Plantinga and Richard Swinburne; 'relative identity', developed primarily by Michael Rea; and 'Latin trinitarianism', most fully defended by Brian Leftow." Critics warn of "tritheism" and "cognitional positivism" (Surin), and — **Stephen Holmes** — that "language refers univocally to the divine and the created" without raising analogy.

**Feminist theology.** **Elizabeth Johnson** targets "speech about God in metaphors that are exclusively, literally, and patriarchally male," renaming the persons "Spirit-Sophia, Jesus-Sophia, and Mother-Sophia," glossing the divine name as "SHE WHO IS," and proposing "Suffering God: Compassion Poured Out." "God's being is identical with an act of communion." **Miroslav Volf** faults Sallie McFague's "Mother, Lover, and Friend" as ending "in modalism... a relationally impoverished monism." **Sarah Coakley** approaches the Trinity through prayer as "an irreducible threeness that always refuses a mere mutuality of two." **Nonna Verna Harrison** (Orthodox) resists replacing the scriptural names: "divine paternity does not mean that the immaterial Father is male."

**Theology of religions.** **Raimon Panikkar** proposes a "cosmotheandric reality," aligning apophatic Buddhism with the Father, personalist theism with the Son, and Advaitic immanence with the Spirit. **Gavin D'Costa** praises the erudition but warns "the symbolic triadic structure subordinates the historical particular narrative of revelation," preferring to read such resonances as *vestigia Trinitatis*. Against pluralists (Hick), D'Costa: "The Trinitarian theology of Christianity helps to explain why the presence of God's Spirit in other religions is the presence of Christ," and a Trinitarian approach "actually attains pluralist goals... in taking difference and otherness utterly seriously."

## 8. The Eastern Orthodox / Greek Patristic Approach

**The monarchy of the Father.** The unity of God is grounded not in a shared impersonal essence but in the person of the Father, sole source (*archē*) and cause (*aitia*). **Zizioulas**: "God, as Father and not as substance, perpetually confirms through 'being' His free will to exist... the Father out of love — that is, freely — begets the Son and brings forth the Spirit... God as person — as the hypostasis of the Father — makes the one divine substance to be that which it is: the one God." **Gregory of Nazianzus**: "The three have one nature... the ground of unity being the Father, out of whom and toward whom the subsequent persons are reckoned."

**The essence—energies distinction (Gregory Palamas).** To hold together transcendence and real participation (*theosis*), the East distinguishes God's unknowable essence from his uncreated energies. **Lossky:** "the essence of God, or His nature... which is inaccessible, unknowable, and incommunicable; and the energies or divine operations... in which He goes forth from Himself, manifests, communicates, and gives Himself." "God's essence is unknowable; creation is deified through participation in God's energies."

**Contrast with the Latin West.** "in general, Greek theology emphasizes the divine hypostases (persons), whereas Latin theology emphasizes the divine nature" — though the sources note this East-begins-with-threeness / West-with-oneness contrast "is also a caricature" now doubted by many scholars. On the *Filioque*, **Photius:** the Spirit proceeds "from the Father alone (ἐκ μόνου τοῦ πατρὸς)... from the same and only cause." **Lossky:** the monarchy of the Father "guards against the *Filioque*," and "by the dogma of the *Filioque*, the God of the philosophers and savants is introduced into the heart of the Living God." On grace, the East insists on participation in the uncreated energies against Western "created grace."

*All texts and quotations retrieved verbatim from the notebook's sources with their internal citations preserved. Companion to the main study document; further sections (e.g., the full Cappadocian orations, Aquinas on the divine names, or the Reformation debates) can be added on request.*